which later helped us develop contacts with at least three powerful Baloch leaders. I recruited all three assets for future usefulness. We found a way to gain a foothold in the region and when the opportunity arose later, we successfully planted our listening posts at key locations,' said Ashfaq.

'But did we really achieve our aim in Afghanistan?' I asked Ashfaq over a few drinks at a bar overlooking the Dhauladhar hills.

'To a certain extent. I will not claim that we got what we wanted. It was also due to the US. Look, the Americans have had a theatre in Afghanistan since the Soviet invasion, which they want to use for a long time. I would say Afghanistan has become an American ammunition testing lab/ Ashfaq smiled. 'That was the reason for our panic.'

The R&AW's fears came true on 24 December 1999 when ISI backed Harkat-ul-Mu-jahideen terrorists hijacked Air India flight IC-814 with one hundred and sixty passengers on board. The ill-fated flight that ultimately landed at Kandahar was guarded by Taliban militants carrying USA supplied stinger missiles on their shoulders. India did not recognise the Taliban regime but the hijacking and the presence of a R&AW officer on board the flight forced the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government to strike a deal with the militants. Later, the MEA issued a statement to salvage the situation.

'Notwithstanding our lack of recognition of the Taliban, our strong reservations about its obscurantist ideologies and our opposition to the manner in which it has permitted itself to be manipulated by Pakistan, we established direct contact with the Taliban during the hijacking of Indian Airlines flight IC-814. The role played by the Taliban during this crisis was noted but